

Comedy 'Well Done' In Cruces

By ED KIMBLE

LAS CRUCES — After seeing "Barefoot in the Park" at Tegmeyer's Dinner Theater, one must wonder how postwar Americans could have survived without the gentle wit of Neil Simon.

When all optimism seems to have faded away, the terminally romantic Simon is around the corner, at a movie house, community or dinner theater, prodding his audiences to laugh at their individual foibles and survive in spite of themselves.

Foibles and surviving them are the meat of "Barefoot in the Park," and CMC Productions serves it well done.

Producer-director Craig McConnell has assembled a cast of local theater all-stars to support two talented newcomers, built them a beautiful set on which to work and directed them well in the fine art of playing for laughs.

Hank Cohen plays the role of Paul Bratter, an aspiring young lawyer fresh from his bar exams but somewhat dull, a "stuffed shirt" of sorts.

Linell Wenzel plays his carefree, energetic bride of six days, Corrie. She's not exactly a woman of the world, but one gets the impression that she could rapidly become one.

The trouble starts when Corrie decides to play matchmaker with her conventional mother, Ethel Banks (played by Edith Bowser) and her highly unconventional upstairs neighbor, Victor Velasco (Larry Bettis).

Paul finds her shenanigans ridiculous. Corrie finds Paul ridiculously too proper. And all hell breaks loose.

Other than Robert Redford and Jane Fonda (who starred in the film version of this Simon classic), few actors could be as perfectly suited to the roles of Paul and Corrie as Cohen and Miss Wenzel. Not only do they play their parts well, they even look their roles.

Miss Wenzel, a newcomer to the El Paso area, is stunningly beautiful but in that soft and wholesome way one associates with the girl next door.

Cohen has that all-American boy look — athletically heavy-set, whimsical smile and handsome, but not threateningly so. Anyone would feel safe buying a used car from this man.

The two have some fine scenes together, notably their 2 a.m. fight scene in Act Two. It's completely stupid, enough so that it never really becomes malicious, and Cohen and Miss Wenzel have the timing down perfectly, making it one of the funniest scenes in the show.

Individually, they also do well. Miss Wenzel makes a charming bride as she flutters around the new apartment in the opening scenes, and Cohen is so thoroughly convincing when he depicts Paul Bratter with a cold in the final act that one member of the audience was overheard asking if his sneez-



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BAREFOOT IN THE PARK by Neil Simon. Directed by Craig McConnell. A CMC Production at Tegmeyer's Dinner Theater, Las Cruces. 8:30 p.m. Fridays and Saturdays through May 27, 2:30 p.m. May 28. Admission \$3 if ordering dinner, \$4 if not. For reservations, call (505) 524-8051.

Carrie Bratter	Linell Wenzel
Telephone Man	Louie Torres
Delivery Man	Craig McConnell
Paul Bratter	Hank Cohen
Ethel Banks	Edith Bowser
Victor Velasco	Larry Bettis

ing was in fact real.

Miss Bowser is, as usual, the show stopper. As Ethel Banks she creates a perfectly dimwitted, slightly neurotic, dull New Jersey housewife. Her fearful responses to Victor Velasco's description of what happened between the two of them after she passed out from too much Ouzo (a Greek liquer) are side-splittingly hilarious.

Bettis' affected accent is somewhat bothersome at first, but Velasco, no doubt, would sport one for effect even if he weren't born with it. Once that is taken into account, it is easy to relax and enjoy this character. Bettis plays him with just the right combination of overstatement and understatement.

Louie Torres doubles as stage manager and Telephone Man. Though he has only two brief scenes in the play, they are memorably wacky. His Bronx accent and hyperventilating laugh do the trick.

McConnell makes one brief entrance as the delivery man from Bloomingdale's, and, without uttering a word, evokes as much laughter as the best line in the play.

These actors make "Barefoot in the Park" sparkle with laughter and just the right dose of meaning. Combined with the fine food and atmosphere at Tegmeyer's, they offer an entertainment value well worth anyone's time and trouble.

REVIVAL

EVANGELIST: Rev. Hoyt Aduddel
SINGER: Don Edwards

Morning Visitation Teams . . .	10:30 A.M.
Mini-Concert	7:15 P.M.
Preaching	7:45 P.M.

Pastor M. H. Konce

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